STUDENT CHECKLIST
JUNIOR/SENIOR DIVISION

We are excited that you are interested in participating in the Greater Austin Regional Science and Engineering Fair (GARSEF)! Please read about the role of student researchers and use this checklist to help complete the registration and prepare for the judging process at the regional fair.

The Role of The Student Researcher(s)

The student researcher is responsible for all aspects of the research project, including enlisting the aid of any required supervisory adults (Adult Sponsor/Teacher, Qualified Scientist, etc.), obtaining necessary approvals (SRC, IRB, etc.), following the Rules & Guidelines of GARSEF, and performing the experimentation, engineering, data analysis, etc. Scientific fraud and misconduct are not condoned at any level of research or competition. This includes plagiarism, forgery, use or presentation of other researcher's work as one's own, and fabrication of data. Fraudulent projects will fail to qualify for competition. GARSEF reserves the right to revoke recognition of a project subsequently found to have been fraudulent.

Participate in your School or District Fair:

Register Online

After your school and teachers have been added to our system, register on-line with STEM Wizard.

- ☐ Choose your topic and your category.
- ☐ Fill out the STEM Wizard Account Creation Worksheet to make sure you have all the information you need prior to registering the account (including addresses, email addresses, and parent/guardian email addresses)
- ☐ Create an account if you are new to STEM Wizard OR activate/update an existing account if you participated last year.
    - If you forget your password, use the "Forgot username and/or password?" link on the login page. This will not work if you use a school email address for your log in. You will have to ask your teacher to reset your password in that case.
    - Every PROJECT will have its own account in STEM Wizard. Students competing as a **team** will each begin STEM Wizard registration in their individual accounts and choose 'team' to register as a team. Once registration is started as a team or individual, it cannot be changed later. If students register as a team, all team members are expected to participate in-person at GARSEF.
    - **STEM Wizard Account Creation Deadline** (Complete both Project + Student Information Milestones) **- October 14, 2026**

- Tips:
  - Make sure to select the correct school name, teacher, and secondary teacher (campus coordinator) for the current year.
  - **School email addresses often block information sent through STEM Wizard.** It is advised to use a non-school email address if possible for the student email address. Each student must have a unique email address (different from other students, teachers, or parent/guardian/secondary email).
  - **The secondary email address must be the parent/guardian email address.** This will allow the parent/guardian to see any important updates, deadlines, and messages sent through STEM Wizard.
- Need help? Go to the STEM Wizard Help page on our website.

Project Design and Approvals

Once you have an account in STEM Wizard, you will need to complete all the milestones listed.

To do this start here:

- ☐ Complete background research on your topic to learn more about the question you are asking and how you might want to design your experiment or engineering project.
- ☐ Write your research plan using the Student Research Plan Template. Be as detailed as possible.
- ☐ Use the STEM Wizard rules wizard (Senior Division) or review the check boxes on the MS Safety and Consent Form (Junior Division) to determine what forms you will need, filling them out electronically, getting all the appropriate signatures, and submitting the completed documents.
  - Senior Division: Rules Quick Reference: Common Paperwork Mistakes and Forms Check
  - Sample Forms can be found in the Project Forms section of the GARSEF Handbook.
  - The forms are intended as guidelines. Therefore, reviewing and following all GARSEF and ISEF rules is required.
  - There are instructions in STEM Wizard and on the STEM Wizard Help page to assist with questions on filling out forms.
- ☐ Submit your research plan in STEM Wizard and begin obtaining your approval signatures.
- ☐ All students should complete and submit their required files and forms in the Files and Forms Milestone by **November 18, 2026**, including pre-approval signatures.
  - These forms are required to be completed prior to experimentation. Forms are intended as guidelines; therefore, reviewing and following all ISEF rules is required.
  - It is the responsibility of the teacher, student, and parent/guardian to make sure that all required signatures for the project are completed on the paperwork prior to experimentation.The regional SRC will not review paperwork until after January 21, 2027, however, at that time signature dates will be checked and projects that are missing the signatures required prior to experimentation will be disqualified.
  - **ALL Projects require the following signatures BEFORE experimentation:**
    - ☐ **teacher/adult sponsor**
    - ☐ **student(s)**

        - ☐ **parent/guardian(s)**
    - Many projects will need additional pre-approval signatures
    - Students must send links within STEM Wizard to obtain required approval signatures after completing their portion of the paperwork in STEM Wizard.
    - Exceptions to Nov. 18 submission:
        - ☐ Form 2A (before or after experimentation) - **Senior Division** only
        - ☐ Form 2C JR (**Junior Division**, if required) and ISEF Forms 2C, and/or Form 7 (**Senior Division**, if required) are submitted after experimentation is complete.
- ☐ The Abstract (in Files and Forms) and an Additional Information milestone will be added to STEM Wizard **January 4, 2027.**
- ☐ Complete the Abstract and Additional Information milestone after experimentation and before **January 15, 2027**. The Files and Forms milestone deadline will be updated in January due to the addition of the abstract.
- ☐ Make sure to meet all deadlines in STEM Wizard, or you will not be able to advance to our fair.

Start your experiment/engineering design

- ☐ After you have completed your paperwork and received your approval signatures, you may begin experimentation.
- ☐ Take notes and photos as you collect your data.

After completion of experimentation/design

- ☐ Review and analyze all collected data and confirm your conclusions are supported by evidence
    - write a clear, concise abstract
    - upload your abstract to STEM Wizard
    - Check the Milestone tab in STEM Wizard to make sure that all milestones are complete and have been submitted.
- ☐ More here?

Create Your Project Board

- ☐ Create your project board following the Display and Safety Rules.
    - **GARSEF will not allow demonstration items, and only paper and photos may be attached to the project board. Boards must be 60" or shorter.** Only boards, binders, paperwork, and laptops/tablets are allowed in the exhibit hall. Use the Project Board Template to help you with your board.
- ☐ **You will need both a physical and a virtual project board for the 2027 fair.** All project boards will be expected to stand on their own or with a stand that fits within the display dimensions.
- ☐ If your school or district has a local fair, you will need to participate and qualify for the regional fair.
- ☐ **All regional deadlines are firm; no late entries will be accepted.**

Advance to the Greater Austin Regional Science & Engineering Fair:

STEM Wizard Steps to Complete Registration

- ☐ If your project is advanced to the regional fair in STEM Wizard, review your paperwork and all milestones to make sure everything is up to date, confirm your category, and make sure your registration is complete, including all required signatures. **Deadline - Jan 21, 2027 at 5:00 p.m.**
- ☐ Your project will be reviewed by the regional GARSEF SRC to determine that all requirements were completed and rules and guidelines were followed.
- ☐ Regularly check your STEM Wizard account beginning January 24, 2027 for messages from the SRC. Please make any requested corrections/clarifications in a timely manner.
- ☐ After GARSEF SRC approval, complete your virtual project board by adding the SRC approved abstract and forms 2C and 7 (if applicable for Senior Division). Save the presentation as a pdf. This should be one document, but can have several pages. Make sure the pdf is less than 5 MB. You may need to reduce the size or number of pictures in your presentation.
- ☐ Upload your completed virtual presentation and other items in the Submissions for Judges Review Milestone in STEM Wizard. **Deadline - Friday, February 5, 2027 at 5:00 p.m.**
- ☐ One week before the fair, check STEM Wizard for your **project number** (ex. ANIM-0013-JR-T). You must write this number on the **back right side** of your project board with a sharpie. This is your booth number. You will need it at registration.
- ☐ Print a copy of your official abstract (download the abstract from STEM Wizard and print - this is the abstract form with the category selected and the SRC signature at the bottom right corner) as well as Form 2C JR (Junior Division) and ISEF Forms 2C and/or 7 (Senior Division) if required for your project. You will need these for Project Board Setup.

Project Board Setup

- ☐ **February 17, 2027, 2:30 - 7:00 p.m., Palmer Event Center**
- ☐ Check in at Palmer Events Center, 900 Barton Springs Road, South Lobby, 2:30 p.m. – 7:00 p.m.
- ☐ Your teacher may have someone check your project in for you.
- ☐ Clear Registration, Display & Safety, and set up your project in your booth. You will need to display your SRC Approved Abstract and ISEF Forms 2C and/or 7 (if required for your project). Don't forget your research paper and data book if you have those. Only boards, binders, laptops/tablets, and project paperwork are allowed at the booth. There are no electrical outlets available for charging electronics at the project booths. If you are bringing a laptop or tablet, make sure it is already charged when you bring it on Thursday. Do not leave electronic items unattended. GARSEF is not responsible for lost or stolen materials at the fair.

Greater Austin Regional Science and Engineering Fair

- ☐ **February 18, 2027, Palmer Event Center**
- ☐ Be prepared for judging. You should be prepared to give your judges a summary of your project in the first 1-2 minutes and then answer questions.
- ☐ Check the Fair Schedule for specific details of the event.

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- ☐ Students are encouraged to bring a book to read in between judges' visits.
- ☐ Dress nicely for your presentation, but remember that you will be standing for a long time on concrete floors, so wear comfortable shoes. It is usually cold in the Exhibit Hall, so you may want to bring a sweater/jacket.
- ☐ Please be at your project 15 minutes before judging. Judging begins at 9:00 a.m. for Seniors and 1:30 p.m. for Juniors.
- ☐ SENIOR DIVISION - Projects that advance to Top-Tier Judging will be notified at the end of the Senior Division Judging session in the morning. Those students' project boards will be moved to a different area while the students are still present. Those students will then be released to have a quick lunch before Top-Tier Judging begins. Not all categories will have students selected for Top-Tier Judging. This does not mean that students released after the morning session will not receive awards.
- ☐ Attend the Awards Ceremony, 7:00 p.m. – 9:00 p.m. to celebrate your achievements and the accomplishments of other Central Texas students. If you can not attend, you must select another student or teacher to pick up any awards you receive and to dismantle your project.
- ☐ Dismantle projects between 9:00 p.m. – 9:30 p.m. Projects not picked up by 9:30 p.m. will be set aside. Projects not picked up by 4:00 p.m. on Saturday, February 20, 2027 will be discarded.
- ☐ Parking will be free of charge for all participants at the Palmer Events Center Garage.

FAIR SCHEDULE

Wednesday, February 17, 2027	2:30 – 7:00 p.m.	Check-in and set-up for the Junior and Senior Projects
Thursday, February 18, 2027	8:00 a.m	Senior Division Judges Sign-in, Review Requirements & Assignments
	9:00 a.m. – 12 noon	Senior Division Judging *(Attending students must be at their project) It is recommended that students be at their project at 8:45 a.m., 15 minutes before judging begins.*
	12:45 p.m.	Junior Division Judges Sign-in, Review Requirements and Assignments
	1:00 – 3:45 p.m.	Top-tier Judging for the Senior Division
	1:30 – 4:30 p.m.	Junior Division Judging *(Attending students must be at their project) It is recommended that students be at their project at 1:15 p.m., 15 minutes before judging begins.*
	5:30 – 7:00 p.m.	Public Viewing of Junior and Senior Division Projects
	7:00 – 9:00 p.m.	Junior and Senior Award Ceremony
	9:00 – 9:30 p.m.	Dismantle Projects

Junior/Senior projects not picked up by 9:30 p.m. on February 18th will be set aside. **Projects not picked up by 4:00 p.m. on February 20th will be discarded.**